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THE NATURE OF SOURCES AND EVIDENCE

CONTENTS

- *Using sources*
- *Archaeological and written sources*
- *Primary and secondary sources*
- *Limitations, reliability and evaluation of sources*

THIS CHAPTER WILL:

- introduce a variety of sources of evidence about Pompeii and Herculaneum
- discuss relevant problems of sources for reconstructing the past
- analyse and evaluate sources for their usefulness and reliability
- explain and evaluate differing perspectives and interpretations of the past.

SOURCES AND EVIDENCE

Historians search for evidence in many places, for example gravestones, inscriptions on buildings, coins, ancient historical accounts, private letters and ruins of buildings. These are called sources of evidence and they provide the information that historians use to construct their accounts of what happened in the past.

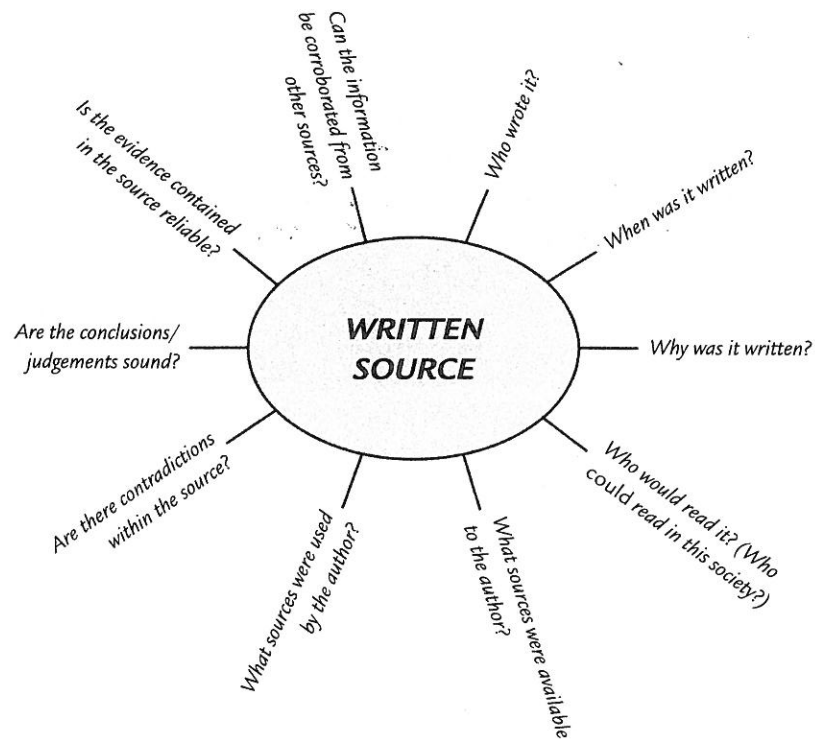
Using sources

All sources provide information, but not all of the information is relevant to a particular line of inquiry. Some sources are incomplete and provide only fragments of evidence. The historian's task is to locate

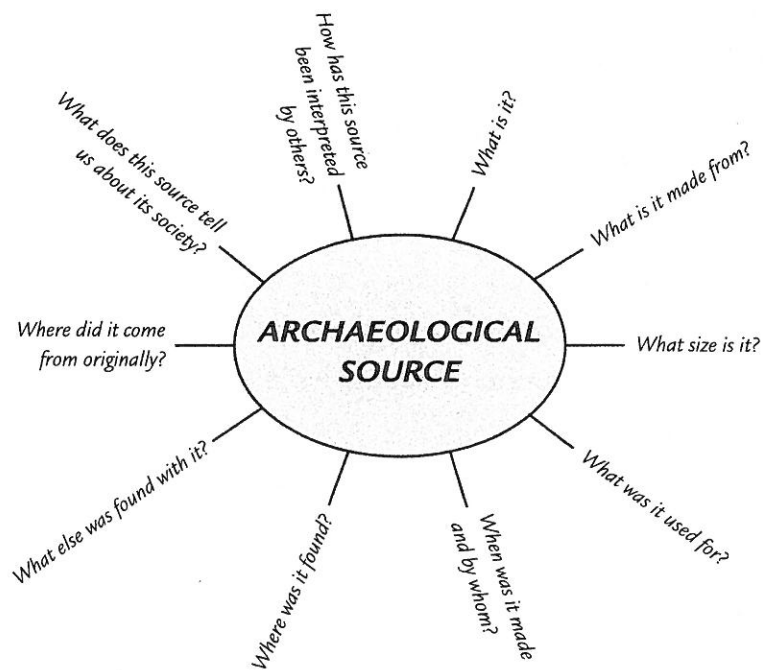
sources and analyse the information they contain to see if it is relevant to their inquiry. The information only becomes evidence when it can help answer particular questions about the past.



Questions to ask of written sources



Questions to ask of archaeological sources



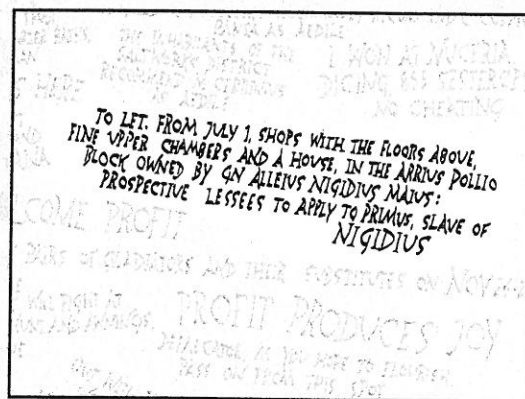
QUESTIONING SOURCES

Here are four questions historians might ask regarding this source in their investigation of life in Pompeii – and some possible answers.

- 1 What is the source?
 - It is a **graffito** from the wall of a building in Pompeii.
- 2 What can we learn about Pompeian life from the graffito?
 - Some shops and houses were rented
 - Some buildings had upper floors
 - Blocks of buildings may have been named for identification
 - Slaves existed and some undertook responsible tasks.
- 3 When was the graffito made? (What date?)
 - We cannot answer this question from the graffito itself. We need to either change the question or find another source of information.
- 4 What other sources may be useful in helping to interpret this source?
 - There may be other inscriptions found referring to Nigidius, providing clues to the period in which he lived.
 - The identification and excavation of the Arrius Pollio block may provide further evidence that may help answer Question 2.

graffito (plural = graffiti)

a drawing or writing scratched on a wall



How do historians use sources?

The use of sources is fundamental to the work of historians, as shown in the steps that most historians follow when undertaking a historical investigation.

Historians:

- plan their investigation
- formulate historical questions and hypotheses relevant to the investigation
- locate and comprehend archaeological and written sources
- analyse sources for their usefulness and reliability
- select and organise relevant information (evidence) from a variety of sources
- identify different historical perspectives and interpretations in primary and secondary sources
- synthesise information from a range of sources to develop and support a historical argument
- present and communicate the findings of the historical investigation.

QUESTIONING SOURCES

- 1 Create four questions a historian might ask of this inscription in an investigation of the role of women in Pompeii.
- 2 Research and/or propose answers to the questions.
- 3 Share and discuss your questions and answers with a member of the class.
- 4 What other types of sources might historians look for to provide a balanced picture of the role of women in Pompeii?

Eumachia, daughter of Lucius (Eumachius), public priestess, in her own name and that of her son, Marcus Numistrius Fronto, built with her own funds the porch, covered passage and colonnade and dedicated them to Concordia Augusta and to Pietas.

Inscription from the entry to the Building of Eumachia in the Civil Forum, Pompeii

Archaeological and written sources

The archaeological and written sources available for study from the cities of Vesuvius are unique. No other archaeological sites in Italy reveal so much about life in Roman times.

Survival of sources

Pompeii and Herculaneum were buried in different ways by the eruption of Vesuvius, which has resulted in different types of sources surviving.

During the eruption, the prevailing winds deposited a steady fall of *lapilli* (pumice stones) on Pompeii. After about 18 hours, an avalanche of hot ash and poisonous gases surged through the town, igniting fires and killing any living thing in its path. The fires burnt everything that was combustible, including anything made from timber and any unprotected objects made from organic material. What remained after the fires was preserved under an ashfall.

Herculaneum experienced the same **pyroclastic** surge of gas and ash, but this was followed by a flow of molten rock that covered the city to a depth of 20 metres. This flow did not reach Pompeii. The molten material slowly cooled and hardened. It **carbonised**

but did not destroy timbers and other organic material, so at Herculaneum there is much greater evidence of timber structures and objects such as food, **papyrus** and skeletal remains. Streetscapes at Herculaneum are more complete than at Pompeii because many upper floors have survived, as well as wooden balconies and staircases. Much less of Herculaneum has been excavated compared to Pompeii, partly because of the depth of the volcanic deposit and partly because the town Resina has been built on top of the site.

Archaeological sources

The physical remains of Pompeii and Herculaneum range from large public buildings made from stone, brick and tile to the fragile bones of unborn babies. Public buildings are sources of evidence for political, commercial and religious practices and leisure activities. Not only the function but also the form of such buildings provides evidence of materials, technology and construction techniques. The remains of aqueducts, pipes, fountains and drains offer evidence of plumbing and **sanitation**. Materials, methods of construction and artistic and architectural styles can yield evidence of trade, workmanship and influences from other places.

papyrus (plural = *papyri*)

writing material prepared from thin strips of the papyrus plant

pyroclastic

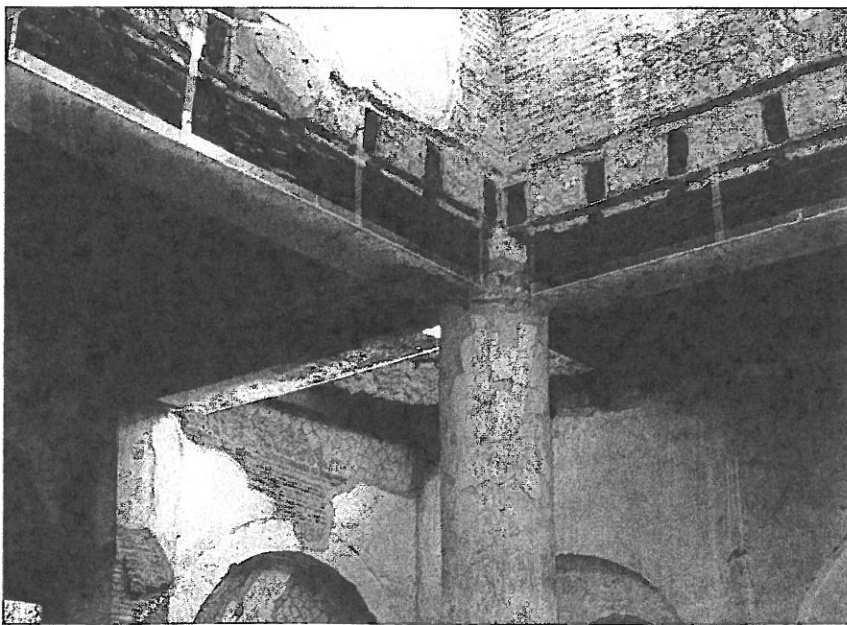
made of fire and burning material

sanitation

drainage and disposal of sewage

carbonise

convert into carbon. In Herculaneum timber doors and beams retained their size and shape but were hardened into a form of charcoal.



Carbonised timber in an interior at Herculaneum

Evidence of furnishing, interior decoration and cooking and dining can be found in private houses. Paintings on the interior walls of houses and workshops, although sometimes purely decorative, often provide information about manufacturing activities such as the **fulling** process and the making of perfume and felt. Millstones, ovens, wine and oil jars and presses, and dozens of hot food bars and taverns provide evidence of the production and consumption of food and drink. Mosaics and paintings depict aspects of daily life such as dancing, gambling and cockfighting, clothing and hairstyles, as well as historical and mythological scenes. Jewellery made from precious metals and gemstones provides evidence of wealth, fashion and craftsmanship.

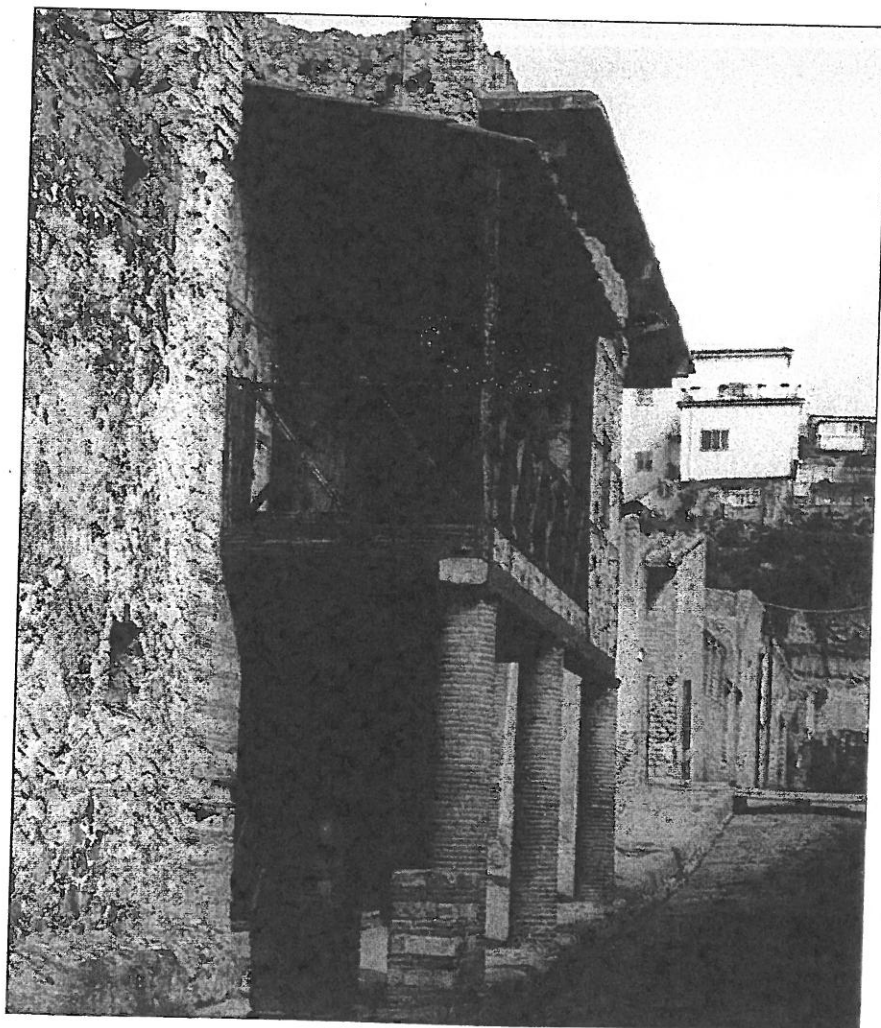
Pollen and plaster casts of plant roots reveal much about public and private

gardens, whether they were ornamental or market gardens – or a combination of both. Such sources help us to imagine the appearance of Pompeii and Herculaneum, with shady trees, colourful shrubs and flowers, orchards and trellises of grapevines.

The remains of animals show that they were kept as pets, for food and for work. Human remains, both the skeletons and the plaster casts formed in the ash cavities of decomposed bodies, reveal much about the people of Pompeii and Herculaneum. Such remains are valuable sources of evidence about age, gender, health, medical history, diet and nutrition, and sometimes even work or occupation. The location and posture of the human remains also provide evidence of the last moments of lives that were ended by the eruption of Vesuvius.

fulling

the process of cleansing and thickening cloth by washing and beating



A two-storey house at Herculaneum

Some of the sources that have been recovered

Pompeii	Herculaneum
• private houses • household shrines • public buildings – palaestra, amphitheatre, baths • forum • temples • brothels • graffiti • inscriptions on buildings and monuments • tombs • statues and decorations • fountains • tools and work equipment • weights and measures • household equipment • water supply • jewellery • pottery • mosaics and frescoes • streetscapes • weapons and armour • cooking equipment	• private houses • household shrines • public buildings – baths, theatre, basilica • scrolls of papyri • wax tablets • graffiti • inscriptions on buildings and monuments • skeletal remains of humans and animals • shops and workshops • tools and work equipment • weights and measures • household equipment • water supply and sanitation • jewellery and glassware • pottery • wooden furniture and building timbers • fishing nets • mosaics and frescoes • organic material including food • streetscapes • cooking equipment



The inscription on a marble plaque in Herculaneum is evidence of the cult of the Augustales, responsible for the worship of deified emperors

ANALYSING SOURCES

- 1 What differences are there in the sources listed from Pompeii and Herculaneum?
- 2 Which sources provide evidence about the following aspects of life in Pompeii and Herculaneum?
 - the economy
 - social structure
 - local political life
 - everyday life
 - religion.
- 3 What evidence is missing from each category in Question 2?
- 4 What differences are there in the types of communities revealed in the excavations at Pompeii and Herculaneum so far?

Types of sources	Examples
Histories	• Cassius Dio, <i>History of Rome</i> 66. 21–23 • Tacitus, <i>Annals</i> 14.17. 1–2, 15.22.2 • Florus, <i>Brief History</i> 1.11. 3–6 • Livy, <i>History of Rome</i> 9.38.2 • Appian, <i>Civil Wars</i> 1.39; 1.50 • Velleius Paterculus, <i>Histories</i> 2.16. 1–2
Geographies, natural	• Seneca, <i>Topics in Natural History</i> 6.1 • Strabo, <i>Geography</i> 5.4.8 • Pliny the Elder, <i>Natural History</i> 3.40; 3.60
Letters	• Pliny the Younger, <i>Letters</i> 6.16; 6.20 • Seneca, <i>Letters</i> 49.1; 70.1; 56.1–2; 86
Poems and speeches	• Martial, <i>Epigram</i> 4.44 • Statius, <i>Silvae</i> 3.5.72–104; 4.4. 78–86 • Cicero, <i>Speech on behalf of Sulla</i>, 60–62
Other	• Vitruvius, <i>On Architecture</i> 2.6.1–2 • Cato, <i>On Farming</i> 135. 1–3

Written sources, which include references to Campania, Pompeii and Herculaneum

Written sources

Many ancient societies used writing extensively. Ancient Egyptian and Sumerian societies recorded a range of texts such as official lists, laws, stories, songs, poetry and scientific texts. The Greeks and Romans continued this rich tradition with the writing of histories, **annals**, drama, philosophies, myths, biographies, political texts, memoirs, geographies and romantic stories.

The names of hundreds of ancient writers have survived but unfortunately their works have not. Ancient historians and other writers mostly wrote on papyrus, clay tablets, **parchment** or wooden tablets. Inscriptions in stone were usually limited to shorter writings such as laws, **proclamations** and dedications on buildings, statues and tombs.

annals

Roman form of history, published annually, which summarised the main events of the year

parchment

the skin of a sheep or goat prepared for writing, painting or engraving

proclamation

an official announcement

In Pompeii and Herculaneum various forms of written evidence have been recovered, including inscriptions, papyri, labels on wine jars, and thousands of messages written on the walls consisting of advertisements, political slogans and personal graffiti.

Contemporary written sources about the cities survived elsewhere. Examples from the Roman period include histories, speeches, natural histories and geographies, poems, letters and other academic texts.

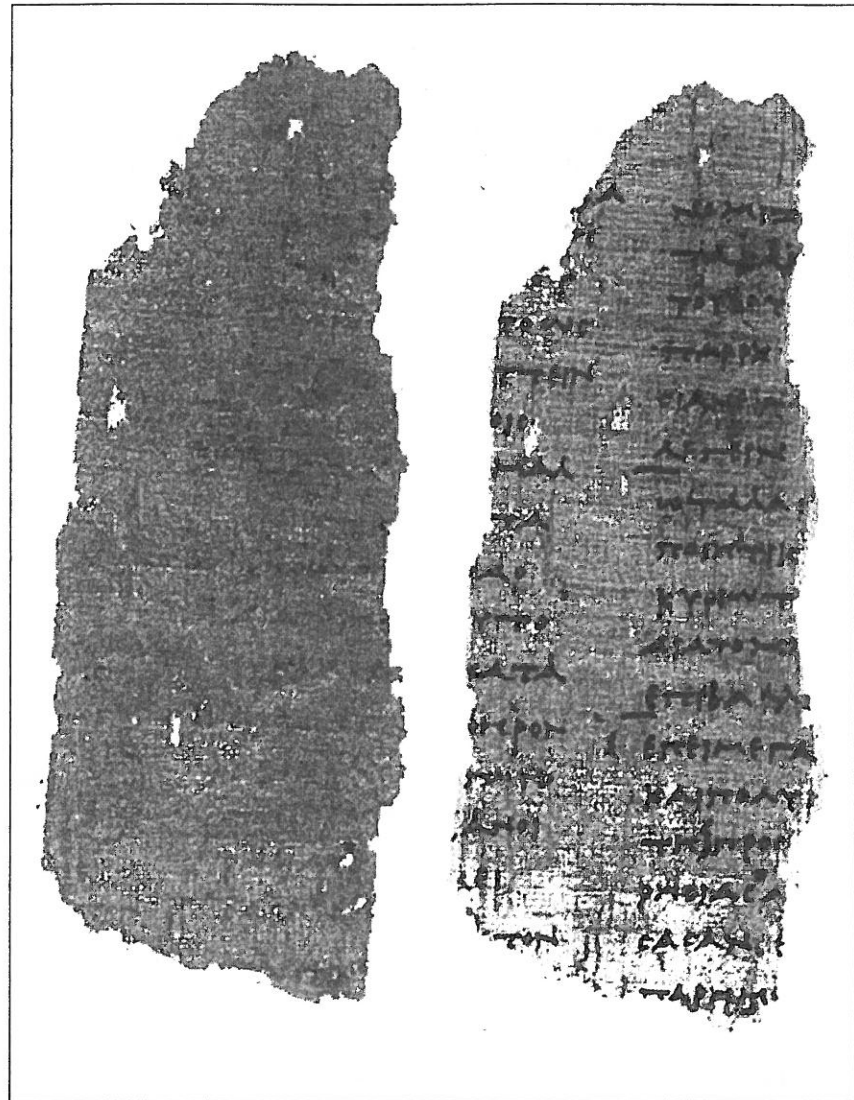
Papyrus scrolls

Greek and Roman writers used rolls of papyrus about ten metres long. Under normal conditions, these materials do not survive damp climates. In Herculaneum, in the eighteenth century, a library of nearly 1800 carbonised papyrus scrolls was found. The papyri were very fragile, but with special equipment and great care, they were unrolled and deciphered. They were written mainly in Greek and most were works of the philosopher Philodemus. Historian Deiss suggests that the library may have been the property of Philodemus' patron, Lucius Calpurnius Piso. This was a wonderful find for historians, and led archaeologists to name the house 'Villa of the Papyri'.

Many ancient rulers were great book collectors, for example Eumenes II of Pergamum in Asia Minor and Ptolemy II of Egypt (285–246 BC). Most ancient rulers kept extensive archives and some kept libraries, but in times of trouble these weren't properly maintained and many texts were lost or destroyed. The recovery of the library in the House of Papyri is evidence that there were local collections of ancient works.

Primary and secondary sources

When investigating the information about a particular period, person or event, historians usually distinguish between primary and secondary sources. Primary sources are those that come from the time being investigated, for example a letter, a speech, an eyewitness description



Papyrus from Herculaneum, written in Greek

or an official document. Secondary sources are written or produced after the period they describe, for example a history, a textbook or an encyclopaedia. Most authors of secondary sources use primary sources in some way, even though they may not mention them directly. The main purpose of secondary sources is to give an overview or an interpretation of what happened in the past. Secondary sources on Pompeii and Herculaneum reflect the era in which they were written, the extent of the excavation and the state of knowledge at the time. More recent secondary sources offer fresh interpretations based on new discoveries or new methods of investigation. They may also provide a survey of different interpretations over time.

Differing interpretations

Sometimes secondary sources can provide differing accounts of what happened in the past. This could be because they drew their information from different primary sources or because they used the same primary sources, but interpreted them differently. An interesting difference in interpretation surrounds the issue of whether Pompeii was in social and economic decline at the time of the eruption.

Was Pompeii in decline?

Penelope Allison, an Australian archaeologist who has been working in Pompeii, argues that the town was in a state of economic and social decline in AD 79. Allison bases her theory on evidence from an examination of 30 houses. Her findings suggest that some properties were abandoned by their owners well before the eruption and had been taken over by squatters. Renovations and decorations were partially finished and rooms were being used in ways that were not appropriate. Farming tools were hanging on the walls over beautiful frescoes in some houses, and statue bases from public monuments had been brought into houses, overturned and used as tables. Other evidence seems to support Allison's argument. Several luxurious private houses had been taken over and converted into workshops. Many major buildings damaged in the earthquake of AD 62 were still not repaired at the time of the eruption, 17 years later.

Archaeologists such as John Dobbins disagree with Allison's interpretation. He argues that the delays in repairing the public buildings after the earthquake were deliberate, and that the city officials were simply taking their time to plan and rebuild on a grander scale than before. He describes the reconstruction as an 'urban renewal project'. Evidence to support his interpretation comes from buildings like those belonging to Julia Felix, a wealthy woman whose properties included a cluster of elegant baths, shops and dining rooms, all

well-patronised by wealthier customers at the time of the eruption.

The idea that after AD 62 many wealthier people left the town was suggested by Seneca who wrote in *Natural Questions*, 'Let us cease listening to those who have turned their backs on Campania, and who have emigrated after this misfortune, and say that they will never go to that region in future'. (*Natural Questions*, 6.1.10).

The interpretation was taken up by Amedeo Maiuri, Pompeii's Site Director between 1924 and 1960. He argued that the earthquake of AD 62 so damaged the homes of the elite that they were plunged into financial crisis. They were forced to sell or rent their homes to people from the lower classes, who promptly converted them into workshops or multiple housing complexes.

Historian Alison Cooley argues that there are other considerations to take into account when deciding whether or not Pompeii was in decline in AD 79. Cooley points out that the rise of the **freedmen** class was typical of Roman society of this time and that there may have been more **social mobility** than previously thought. She also argues that some wealthy families remained in the town. She draws on the recent evidence provided by the tomb enclosure of a powerful and wealthy family, the Lucretii Valentes. Collating a range of evidence, she argues that they remained in the area, playing a major political and civic role. However, Cooley acknowledges that this is only one family so the evidence is rather limited.

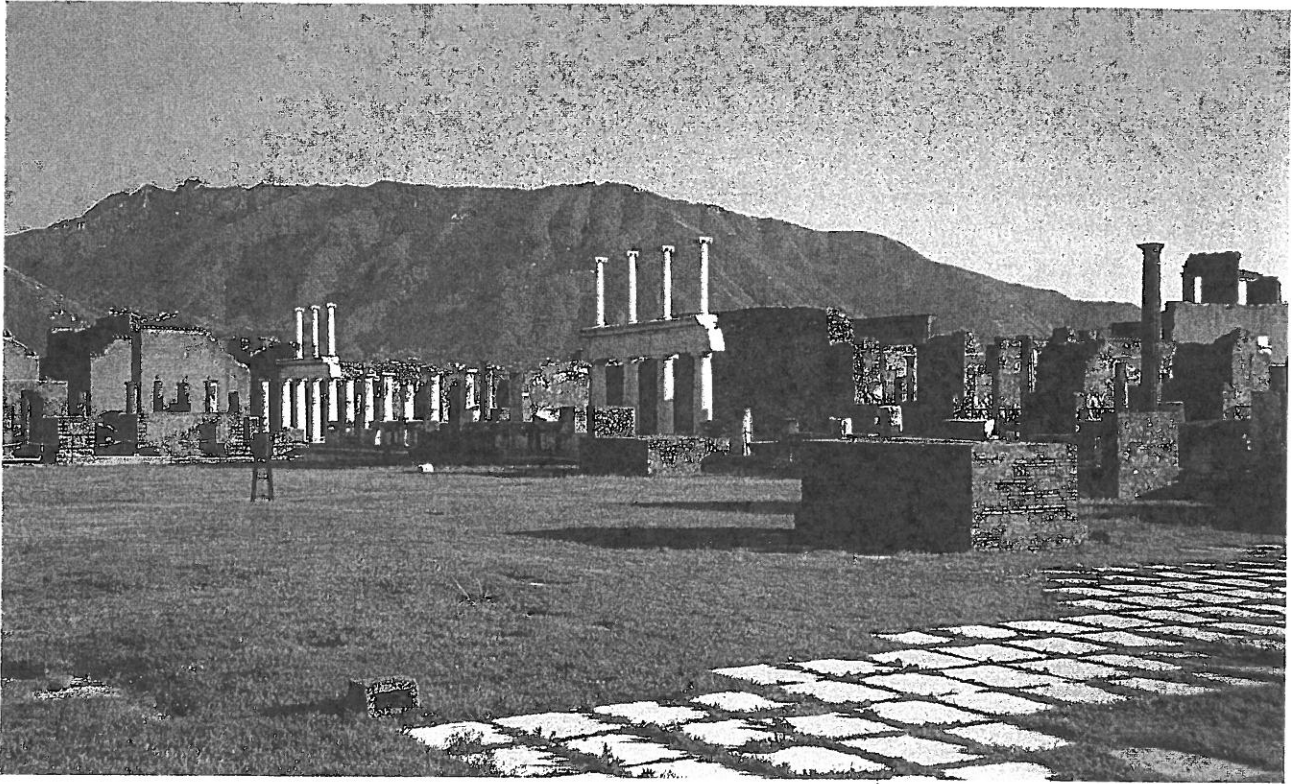
She also argues that the conversion of larger homes to workshops may not be linked to the earthquake. The changes cannot be dated and could have been undertaken any time in the first century AD. Furthermore, it appears that it was not unusual for a Pompeian house to serve as both a home and place of business or production. Perhaps some of the wealthier families were diversifying their economic base. If some objects appear to be out of place according to

freedmen

former slaves who had gained their freedom, many of whom were successful in business

social mobility

movement between social classes



The forum at Pompeii

our modern views, it may not have been so in Roman times. Cooley points out that the recycling of materials, including statue bases, was quite common.

Today the forum at Pompeii is grassed. Is the absence of the original marble paving evidence of a decline – or the result of scavenging in ancient times or during early excavation?

Thus historians and archaeologists disagree over the 'decline' of Pompeii. However, there is agreement that some of the old established families had left their properties in Pompeii before the eruption of AD 79, but we do not know exactly when, nor do we know the circumstances. It may have been part of the process of 'abandonment' as Allison suggests, or perhaps these families simply sold their town properties and moved onto estates in the surrounding countryside or further afield.

Limitations, reliability and evaluation of sources

Limitations

Despite the extraordinary range of archaeological sources that has come to light at both Pompeii and

Herculaneum, there are some significant 'gaps' in the evidence. There is a lack of written sources from the people themselves about their everyday life, their dreams, thoughts and outlook on life. Another archaeological site, the village of Deir el Medina in Egypt, produced a great range of everyday written texts. In Pompeii and Herculaneum no personal letters, poems, shopping lists or stories have come to light. There have been two finds of legal documents in Pompeii and another in Herculaneum which give some insight into business and legal activities, but sources containing the personal lives and thoughts of the inhabitants have so far not been uncovered. Graffiti inscriptions, which were written on the walls of buildings in both cities, provide glimpses of personal thoughts, but their reliability is difficult to assess. Perhaps the most well-known written sources about Pompeii are the two letters written by Pliny the Younger years after the eruption of Vesuvius.

The map on page 26 shows how little of Herculaneum has been uncovered so far. This limits the amount of evidence

COMPARE INTERPRETATIONS

- 1** Identify and list the evidence used to *support* and evidence used to *oppose* the idea that Pompeii was in decline at the time of the eruption of Vesuvius in AD 79.
- 2** What additional evidence would you need before you accepted either interpretation?
- 3** Which interpretation do you think is more likely? Why?
- 4** Can you offer a different explanation for the change in usage of certain private buildings and the delay in the repair of major public buildings?

that is available for a study of everyday life. The main public and political area, which would normally lie near the Forum, has not been recovered, limiting the evidence on this important part of civic life. Commercial areas too were often located near the Forum, so we may well be drawing conclusions about commercial life, manufacturing and trade, based on very little evidence. So far, an amphitheatre has not been found at Herculaneum. At this stage, we may conclude that the town did not possess one or that it has not yet been found. The sites also tend to reveal more about the wealthy and literate than the poor, particularly the lives of poor or lower-class women.

The sites are also open to changing interpretations over time. With the introduction of new technologies and methodologies and the discovery of new evidence, interpretations must change. Historians and archaeologists may also unwittingly be viewing the evidence through 'modern eyes'. In relation to interpretation of room

usage, for example, the modern Western assumption is that rooms have a single purpose, such as dining rooms or bedrooms, yet in ancient times they may well have served several purposes.

In Chapter 3, the limitations of sources will be discussed in more detail in association with the different aspects of life revealed by the evidence.

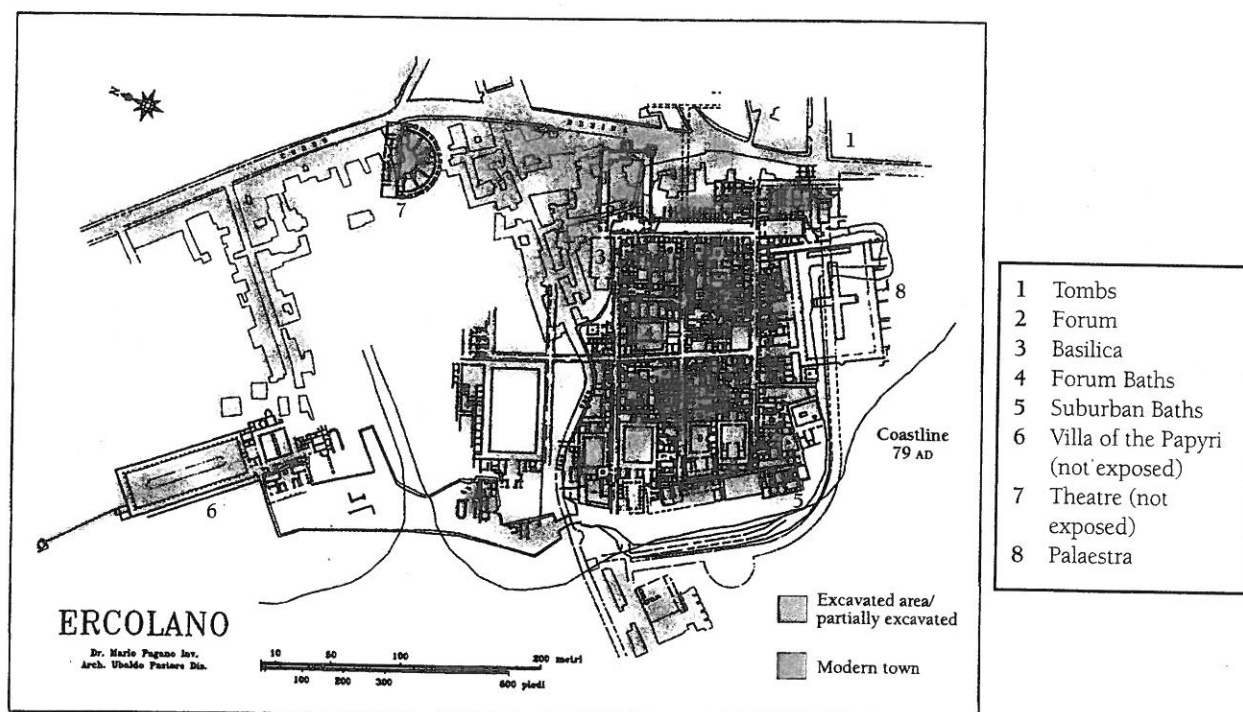
Reliability

To make effective judgements, historians must decide how useful sources are for the topics that they are studying. They need to ask questions such as: Is the source biased in any way? Does the source contain facts or opinions? How reliable is this source for the topic being studied?

Bias in sources

A biased source gives mainly a one-sided view of an event or argument. The source will probably favour one side or a particular point of view. However, a biased source can still be useful to a historian for showing that particular point of view.

Herculaneum: showing the excavated area and the modern town



There are several types of bias.

- Deliberate distortion or untruth – telling lies, leaving out important facts or using extreme, emotional language
- Limited access to evidence can result in a biased or one-sided account. A historian should consider what else would be needed to give a more rounded, reliable account.
- Distortion to serve a particular purpose. The questions need to be asked: What point of view is being expressed? What is the reason for writing? How could a historian use this source?
- Beliefs or opinions of the writer could be one-sided due to prejudice of race, gender, religion or social class.

Determining bias

To determine bias in a source, the following questions should be asked.

- 1 Have emotive words or phrases been used?
- 2 What is the impression given by the source?
- 3 Are any facts omitted?
- 4 Is the selection of facts balanced?
- 5 Has the writer any reason to be one-sided?
- 6 What do you think the origin of the descriptions may be?
- 7 Is the writer trying to influence a particular group of people?
- 8 What is the author's purpose in writing?

Evaluation of sources

The evaluation of sources involves the considerations and processes discussed throughout this chapter. Although some specific and different questions are asked of written and archaeological sources, as outlined in the mindmaps at the beginning of the chapter, the general approach to evaluation is similar, involving:

- examination of sources in their context
- investigation to determine origin and purpose

DETERMINING BIAS

This is an extract from a poem written by Publius Papinius Statius. Read the extract and note how the words chosen create a particular impression.

Mild winters and cool summers temper the climate, its shores are lapped by the quiet waters of a harmless sea. Untroubled peace reigns there, and life is leisurely and calm, with quiet undisturbed and sleep unbroken. . . . Why should I now praise the magnificent scenes and adornments of this land, the temples and wide halls spaced by countless columns, the two great theatres, one open and one covered, and the quinquennial contests that rival the Capitoline festival? Around about you will find a variety of pleasures: whether you please to visit Baiae with its steaming springs and alluring coast, or the prophetic Sibyl's hallowed cave, or the hill made famous by the Ilian oar, whether you prefer the flowing vineyards of the Bacchic Gaurus, . . . or the health giving lake of Aenaria and Stabiae?

Statius, *Silvae*, III.v.65–110

- 1 What impression of the region is given by the source?
- 2 List the words used to create that impression.
- 3 Is it possible to substitute words that have a similar meaning but are not as emotive?
- 4 Is it possible to rewrite the description so that it is not biased?

Statius, who was born in Naples, was obviously proud of his birthplace. The line after the extract above asks, 'Shall I recount to you the thousand beauties of my country?' He may have written the poem to persuade his wife Claudia to move to the area. He begins his description with the line 'This is the spot where I would love to bring you'.

- 5 If we consider the purpose of the letter, does this alter your evaluation of the source?
- 6 How might you check the accuracy of this source's description of Campania?
- 7 Could this source be *useful* to a historian investigating what the region of Campania was like in ancient times?

- questioning to reveal evidence sources may contain in relation to a historical inquiry
- testing of sources for accuracy and reliability.

After evaluating sources, historians then decide how they will use the evidence gained in their inquiries and ultimately how the sources will shape the interpretation of the past presented.